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Darius Brubeck

Pianist, compose, author, and educator Darius Brubeck, eldest son of Dave Brubeck, has led a productive career internationally. He established the Centre for Jazz and Popular Music in South Africa, and co-authored with his wife Catherine the book Playing the Changes.

Darius was interviewed via Zoom on June 29, 2024 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I'm very pleased to have Darius Brubeck with me this morning. And you are aware, you said you're in a studio with your brother?

DB: Yeah, my brother Chris. In Danbury, Connecticut.

MR: I was wondering if you and Catherine were living out of a suitcase.

DB: We are, for the time being. We actually live in Rye, which is southeast of London about two and a bit hours away, after living in London for ten years right in the middle of it in Camden Town, which is legendary within the music community. Camden Town, that area. You know where Camden Market is?

MR: Okay.

DB: A supergraphic of Amy Winehouse on one of the industrial building walls, we lived right above the canal. And in Camden Town every night is party night so after ten years of that and setting up my group and professional network to the level it needed to be, we decided to live like grown-ups and move out of London. And we moved down to Rye, R-Y-E, because, in a way because that's where Henry James lived.

MR: No kidding. What an attraction. Yeah.

DB: Yeah. And we went there as tourists to see his house, which is a national trust property, and we thought you know Henry James did the same thing. He had a flop on the West End. As many of his novels as have been turned into films, he was, you know they're well plotted and there are great characters, and this has nothing to do with jazz, I'm sorry.

MR: That's okay.

DB: He was a flop as a playwright and he decided well what the hell, I don't need to be in London to write books, that's what I'm good at, and he moved down to Rye.

MR: And then he became more productive I would imagine.

DB: Yeah.

MR: Yeah. I'd like to start with a couple of inquiries about your time in South Africa. When you arrived there as a Caucasian American, what was your place? Apartheid was still in effect. How did you fit?

DB: I exploited the hell out of my status as — as you put it, Caucasian but I would simply say white and I'm okay with that, white American. I — if anything — exaggerated my accent. I simply ignored Apartheid and had a built-in excuse not to know about it if you see what I mean. Of course I knew a lot about it because my wife, Cathy, or Catherine as she has signed off on the book, grew up there and was very politically active. But we just played my identity hand to the hilt and got by with a lot a local white South African wouldn't.

MR: Did it help you with your establishment of your jazz center and reaching out for community support and funding and all those things that go along with a teaching job?

DB: Yeah. Not only American and white, but a Brubeck. I mean you know that's holding some strong cards. And I'm not ashamed to say that. It would be stupid not to use it.

MR: Had Dave played in South Africa?

DB: Yeah. In 1976. And it was just before the cultural boycott had been announced and there was some opposition to it but by — well mainly what this did is we went on tour in South Africa as The New Brubeck Quartet. That was Dave, Chris on bass and trombone, and Dan, and our agent at the time Associated Booking Corporation (ABC) — I never go into this kind of detail with journalists but I suppose for an archival interview it's good to know that kind of stuff — and parenthetically every imaginable pertinent document on anything we talk about can be found in the Brubeck Collection at the Wilton Library, Wilton, Connecticut. Anyway so our agent had signed a contract that we hadn't seen because he had that signing power, and Dave said we wouldn't go. And the agent said, "Well then that's going to be litigation and you don't want that." But what Dave said, "Well I'm not going anyway unless we establish certain conditions. And these were that we would have a local black supporting act and that because Chris played trombone we absolutely needed a black bass player. Well we absolutely needed a bass player but it was understood what we really needed was for a local South African black person to be on the stage simultaneously with us as well as a support act, or the opening act as they say in the States, support act in kind of the rest of the Anglo-sphere, and that the audiences could not be racially segregated. Now in the back of Dave's mind was they can't meet these conditions and we won't go. But they did. Except in one city, ironically, and that was Durban, which is where I ended up, at what was then the University of Natal. But we did the tour and became very good friends with Vic Ntoni — spelled N-T-O-N-I — who was the bass player and he had worked with Abdullah Ibrahim, known as Dollar Brand at the time. When Victor came to the States, came to the U.S., with help from Dave and the family to study at Berklee, he hooked up with Hugh Masekela who was living in the Bronx at the time. And I should say that well a lot of this is in the book. I'll try not to repeat too much of it, but also my future (at that time) future wife Catherine Shallis or

Cathy Morphet — Shallis was her maiden name. Cathy Morphet from her second husband — first husband. I'm further down the line — M-O-R-P-H-E-T — went on the road as kind of a liaison person but the thing is with the local contacts that she had and on the surface the local contacts were some music people that she knew. She had always been involved with jazz, and kind of less overtly with a kind of liberation organization people who were, you know that was all kind of off-the-record stuff but constantly taking the temperature — were we going to suddenly hit a boycott situation or were we going to get shut down by the regime. We were kind of in an uncomfortable place, because — vulnerable to attack from the government or from the left. So Cathy's contacts were valuable in explaining our position, explaining the contract I just explained to you.

MR: Did you agree with the Artists United Against Apartheid? Did you feel that that refusal to come in ensuing years was a positive or a negative?

DB: Well the UDF, the United Democratic Front, which was an open organization, it wasn't a banned organization like the ANC, the African National Congress. The United Democratic Front always kind of apologetically said to the South African public that a boycott is a blunt instrument and you know we can't always choose between the good guys and the bad guys, so you know we'll just say a boycott's a boycott. But then there were so many individual exceptions that refined — made the blunt instrument rather surgical. But as I recall, now we're talking about between 40 and 30 years ago so my memory may not be totally adequate on this because — that's not in the book — but UDF was primarily driven by or let's say staffed by — because it was driven by genuine popular movement but it was staffed by people who had the leisure and the education and an office were people in the labor union movement and they were the people that we actually talked to. And the people that they talked to overseas were correspondingly affiliated with labor unions in different countries, in the United Kingdom, France and the Netherlands, Germany. So there were always channels of communication. And then, and this is in the book, finally — this part, not the part I just told you — Johnny Clegg — do you know who Johnny Clegg was? You know quite a cultural hero and a unique individual on many levels, got together the South African — SAMA — South African Music Association. So then we had like an official channel then, because it had a proven popular base and musicians joined it or not. They were free not to but those who already had international careers certainly found it to their advantage. And that became a way of negotiating all these political difficulties. And the usual agreement was that we would be very disapproving of artists who simply came to play in Sun City, which very often would be the anchor date for big names and we didn't even recognize that Bophuthatswana was really a country, although that was again a kind of boycott busting

maneuver to say well it's an independent country. You know a casino state. There were several such.

MR: I see.

DB: So called tribal homelands that in effect were funded by gambling. And so we'd be down on that but then on the other hand like you know when artists came who identified with the struggle, and you could tell that pretty easily by the content of their music, their shows, the make-up of their band, they were welcomed, usually on the condition that they provided some kind of outreach, you know usually in the form of a workshop or workshops from members of the group, and then people on the other end — well by then I was in charge of the jazz program at the University of Natal as it then was, so I would host some major people on campus and students would benefit from contact with them. And that was all fine. There was no political damage to their careers when they did what we perceived to be the right thing.

MR: Did you benefit from your students as well as they benefitted from you? I'm thinking about my own experience of working with musicians who may not have come through what we call a schooled music education, that they were ear learners and learned on the gig. And I wonder if you had students like that and what you might have gained from that association?

DB: I didn't have students like that — some students like that — they were all like that. Every one of them. And I gained a huge amount from that, of course. But also I was that was myself, surprisingly. I wasn't the product of a jazz program. You know I didn't go to Berklee or Indiana University or North Texas State. The degree to which I had formal music training at a university level was in ethnomusicology. So I was very open to and curious about what processes enabled these musicians to be as good as they all were anyway, without the sort of background that you're talking about. And I knew, because they all told me this, that what they wanted to learn was what you got from formal education. There's a myth in some circles that whether they're talking about me or some years later other university people were imposing our standards, our processes on people who were already musical and thereby depriving them of something — not at all, it certainly wasn't my way and I don't know of other instances either. They came to university not to learn what they could already do, but you know what I mean?

MR: Well said, yes.

DB: So you know if you listen to The Jazzanians or — do you know about — yeah, you would know about The Jazzanians. But what you hear is, you know, tremendous feel, great coherence in the rhythm section, a completely different approach to soloing, you hear borderline but somehow not to my ear anyway, I'm acclimatized to what would be intonation issues.

MR: I'm so glad you brought that up. Because I was going to ask this and I was trying to figure out how to ask it.

DB: Yeah?

MR: But I've wondered if it's been my imagination that when I listen to some West African but South African music, I hear as if their guitars are tuned slightly different and they may — the horn players may play a little sharp, or just there's something there and I can't quite figure it out, but it's part of the sound.

DB: It's part of the sound. And again, my ethnomusicology background made that okay with me or as I've brought in other people to do workshops and they say, "Wow, you know, your kids play with a lot of soul but you know I just wish they'd play in tune." And that was a thing, and sometimes I felt the same way and sometimes I didn't. It depends on context. Have you ever conducted a big band? A student big band?

MR: Many times, yes.

DB: If you're doing a Neal Hefti chart and the sax section is sharp, it's not going to sound good. But if on the other hand you played a chart that would be somebody's transcription of the African Jazz Pioneers, which was a terrific small big band back in the day, and they were trained like the musicians I interacted with a lot in England, you know to — you know they'd have their small group gigs but they'd be in the Ronnie Scott's All-Stars, they'd be in the BBC Big Band, they came up through the National Jazz Orchestra. So they'd nail the parts and play them exactly in tune. This is fictional. It didn't actually happen. But I'm sure that would just sound wrong. It isn't how the music was conceived in the first place.

MR: Did it have anything to do with the music in the townships, if that is a correct term to use,

DB: It is.

MR: Was it keyboard based or was it more guitar oriented so that they weren't concerned with tuning up to A 440. Maybe I'm going too far with this.

DB: Well this is getting quite technical but when I started — by the way I don't come from a big band background so I was learning on the job. But one of the things I knew — it's no longer true but we're back in 1982 and I thought the only absolute basis for having a university jazz program is you have to have a big band because you're going to pull in some people from the community, you'll pull in people from other departments who might have learned instruments, they might be on university staff or they might be medical students or whatever they are, but you create a core and that's the beginning of a culture and a network that you won't get if you're just going to get five jazz pianists and a singer and a guitar player. You know the first step really is to, you know, is to create the big band and so I had to do something that I'd never done before. And so all of these things came to the surface but now I'm remembering more directly what your question is.

Yeah, keyboards because churches have pianos. Guitars because at least in Natal there is a very strong Zulu guitar tradition. And yes they do use different tunings and it's no more like classical guitar than flamenco guitar is like classical guitar. It's its own thing — virtuosic solo music. You don't really get guitar bands. You get a front guy who is the star, is the guitar player.

MR: Was your early jazz ensemble efforts, was it integrated?

DB: Completely. Had to be.

MR: Well can you expand on that? Why did it "had to be?" You mean because you wanted it to be or because it was mandated somehow?

DB: I wanted it to be and also it was practical because — well I dropped into a situation where none of this existed before. You know? I wasn't appointed to Champaign-Urbana where I could take over from Dave Sporny or something, you know. So in order to fill sections, and I never had to apologize or explain this — apologize for or explain this — but I had to draw on every community just to have a band, to have enough trumpet players, trombone players, sax players. And I actually had at first a lot of support from professionals who had just never had a rehearsal band to play in and they loved it on the one hand, those would be you know from black and Indian and then from the white side of it there were people who had been in the military or police that had bands, and then quite surprisingly, and this was a huge help in the first two or three years, the Natal Philharmonic Orchestra was just getting established and they had auditions from all around the world and you would know how hard it is to get an orchestra job if you're an American graduate, there are just not enough jobs so they would — we got some good British, Canadian and American trombone players — brass players in general — there was one guy who worked in the British Consulate who played very good kind of dance band trumpet, and some good orchestra players. And that was a core educational experience for you know — again I want to stress in many ways the black students or students who weren't white, who weren't formally educated, were good musicians but they just weren't used to reading and they weren't used to playing parts. They could work out a part faster than anyone you or I ever taught, a second part, a third part. They'd just do it through eye contact with the lead player somehow.

MR: Love it.

DB: Okay, again we're playing "Basie Straight Ahead" or something like that, and well they'd be sitting next to someone who was doing it right and getting the phrasing right and all of that. And I mean that changed the world you know.

MR: I just — I can almost I think picture your first few rehearsals. Because I've been in situations where you have both ends of what you're describing and sometimes I would

say, “All right let’s do ‘C Jam Blues’ here’s what it sounds like. Get everybody to play something together to just get some motion going.

DB: Yeah. Right. Well then in that case if there was any resistance it would be to reading it at all. You know. But if you said after three choruses, okay, let’s see, how would I work through that — “Okay, head twice — there’s been a lot of brass let’s have a guitar or a piano solo, first trombone set a riff.” You know? And then —

MR: Well I’m going to move on but I just wanted to make a comment that your description of the Brubeck group in the late ‘70s when you went there, it’s so ironic because I’ve spoken to many elderly musicians who went through that over here — traveling in the south, segregated audiences, no white or black musicians on the stage at the same time, and what you’re describing just — I don’t have a question here, it’s just an observation that is worth noting.

DB: Yeah. Well we, you know as I said, we broke those rules, we were an exception, the rules were not abrogated as a result but we just didn’t play the game by their rules. And, you know, obviously we’re proud of that and obviously that impacted on what my work would be later.

MR: Okay, well speaking of impacted, I wanted to talk about your own composition process, and earlier today I listened to your quartet, this goes back to a concert at Queens Hall in Edinburgh, and “Mamazada”?

DB: “Mamazala.”

MR: “Mamazala.” I got this feeling that it was a combination of church music, blues, and some classical and some South African thing in there. And I’m wondering how that particular piece came to be and if it’s a model for how you usually work?

DB: Well everything you’ve said about it is true but it’s not a model for me because it was composed by one of my former students who was also in the Jazzanians and his name is Zim Ngqawana. And you’ll find his name on the album and in the book so you’ll be able to spell it. But you’re very correct, the kind of piano voicings in the head are just church. And that comes from the tradition Christian missionaries introduced that kind of harmony in choral singing and Africans really excel at that. Again, they’re not reading, they just know that young men have higher voices than older men and women have higher voices still, and they do four part like, you know, it’s like magic really that it sounds so good. And the piano does the same kind of thing. But the improv section if you analyze it is actually “Confirmation” slowed down. So that’s the jazz bit and the joke that the African musicians had about that particular piece, which is quite popular, is they called it “ECM Mbaqanga.”

MR: ECM as in the record label?

DB: Yeah, right.

MR: Okay, followed by what was that you said?

DB: Mbaqanga. It's kind of their blues form. It's their roots music which has a very predictable kind of harmonic, you know, chordal progression and it can go on infinitely like a blues with variations like the blues but always the same kind of harmonic cycle, open endedly you know for exposition and then someone says, "Oh it's time to play the head again" and they do. But it can be very arranged or not arranged at all, but yeah, just think of it as like the blues but for South Africans.

MR: Okay. And after that I listened to a tune called "Tsakve."

DB: Yeah that's Abdullah Ibrahim and that is a minor blues in the Western sense.

MR: Both tunes had something I really like and that is a unison with the left hand piano and the string bass.

DB: Yeah.

MR: I love that sound. I don't know why more people don't do it.

DB: Well I can't — I don't know which other people are not doing it, but I would hazard a guess is that it would tend to expose any rhythmic differences in just exactly where you feel the beat. But people do do it. Chick Corea's done it with Miroslav for example or there's some of that in "Return to Forever." Okay this is getting int —

MR: But it has to be worked out sometimes beforehand, you know, if you just have a pick-up group it's unlikely that you're going to be doing something like that.

DB: Oh hell no.

MR: Have you had moments trying to balance your own musical vision with that of your father and people's expectations when they go to hear any group that has the name "Brubeck" in it.

DB: Yeah.

MR: What is that like?

DB: Look sometimes I wish I didn't have to devote so much program space to "Blue Rondo" and "Take Five." But I know that's — in a way it's too bad because it's kind of — it's an understood contract with the audience and it's silly to deny that expectation. I mean people come to a concert to have a good time you know. And you don't want to say well that's wrong. And it's, you know again it's benefitted me terrifically to know that with that platform I can play a lot of original music, and my main — well my programming for years has relied on pretty much a formula that has variations within it, is I know I'm going to end with "Take Five" and even if I've played Cecil Taylor, which I don't — but I mean whatever I play if I end with "Take Five" people will be happy. Okay. So that licenses whatever goes before it. So I play a lot of original music and I'm kind of a campaigner or advocate for South African jazz. So I play those tunes. I don't play — I used to play a lot of standards in South Africa because again the — you know I was

bringing something from my hemisphere, my side of the Atlantic that they loved, they do pretty well but they always want to learn more about that. But then since I left South Africa I hardly do them. I play original music because people don't need to pay 20 pounds to hear what they could hear in the back of a pub.

MR: I see. I'm going to take you back a little bit. I was interested to read that the Brubeck family in the early days had financial struggles, before things started happening.

DB: Yeah.

MR: And I think you were four years old when Dave suffered that accident that made his back an issue. Do you remember those early days and sometimes kids aren't aware that — how are they going to pay the rent. You know we're not involved in paying the rent when we're kids, but I guess my question is do you remember that the family was struggling for a while and that Dave and Iola both were trying to figure out how to make a living in music?

DB: Of course I know all about that retrospectively. I'm trying — look I think they were pretty good at making us feel secure no matter what and for a young child, whatever your parents accept as normal is normal. They define that. I was on the beach when that happened — the diving — well "diving accident" I don't mean scuba, I mean he went to dive into a wave and it was just too shallow and he hit his head and he had to be pulled out of the water and he had literally broken his neck and he was taken off the beach and of course that was upsetting but that's because, you know, dad is injured. But it wasn't upsetting in terms of thinking oh what are we going to eat. That thought never crossed my mind. But what I do remember as I became older and more worldly was how precariously we were living with, you know, in terms of accommodations and like — there are all sorts of stories, I mean staying in campsites, California state campsites out of season because it was cheap, all of us going — well all of us was in those days mainly my parents plus Michael, you know just being in the car, sleeping in the car, driving around. When Chris was born we still had hotel accommodations of the same size and Iola using the top drawer of a dresser to put him in, with some blankets. And you know it goes on and on, stories like that. But I wish I could quote it exactly but you know what Tolstoy said, you know all happy families are happy in the same way. It's the famous introduction to *Anna Karenina*. So we were a happy family. Mom read stories, Dad played music. We sometimes went to concerts and maybe that was because we had nowhere else to go.

MR: And you got your name on the guest list.

DB: Yeah. We were all happy.

MR: Yeah. It must have been quite a — the move to Connecticut.

DB: Yeah.

MR: What an adventure.

DB: Well that was a real uprooting. I remember it very clearly because it was 1960, it was a presidential year. Kennedy was elected. Kennedy ran against Nixon and won. Barry Goldwater was a big name in those days. And for me that just flags up so many historical things. But mainly what I remember was moving into a different, very different physical environment. Even Northern California is pretty arid and warm. We were in Oakland so we were, you know the prevailing vegetation was eucalyptus. You'd smell that every morning. Eucalyptus and pine and Dave and Iola had this marvelous architect-designed house which is in itself iconic. It's near the beginning of a movement called NorCalMod — Northern California Modern — which is kind of Frank Lloyd Wright based. And you can look things up about it. I try not to go down too many tangents — follow too many tangents — but NorCalMod — to living in — renting Irving Townsend's house on Newtown Turnpike. If you look at jazz history, recorded jazz history, he was a significant producer for Columbia Records. And Dave was just starting to break through and be a national name and moving to Connecticut was really at the behest of Columbia Records. And they wanted to send Irving Townsend to California to set up an L.A. branch, so they could offer this house, which was really nice and it was on a farm, it was kind of a rural property. Connecticut is, as you know, very humid, very green. And it was like what we called a New England salt box. You know white, with wooden shutters — excuse me I have to get some water —

MR: Sure. [pause] go ahead.

DB: So think about what the east coast was like in those days, and who was there. We were about a half a mile from Benny Goodman's house in Connecticut. We were — in urban terms say blocks, but the reality was that we were a large hayfield away from John Hammond's house. Leonard Bernstein was, you know a drive away. He wasn't that close but he wasn't that far. John Hersey was around there someplace, the author. The next door neighbors included a painter whose reputation is kind of gone now, but Jean Jackson who was very close to Xenia Cage, John Cage's wife, who was a frequent visitor, which meant that sometimes Virgil Thompson came up to the country to hang out and, you know, in a few words we had gone from an ambience in California where you know, little league baseball was kind of a good metaphor from where we were to where it was happening at the time.

MR: Going into the majors.

DB: Dave and Iola were just — acclimatized quickly and wonderfully to that.

MR: I mentioned that I was in your house, the Wilton, Connecticut house, and I have this memory, one of the first things I spotted after of course the beautiful grand piano, was a

Baldwin Exterminator amp against the wall. And I said oh my God I haven't seen one of those in — and to me it informs something about you boys I think. Right?

DB: Yeah.

MR: That you weren't just into jazz, that there was other stuff and that you played electric instruments and all, but the amp spoke to me.

DB: Well yeah, and that was a correct reading of that. Yeah Chris and Dan and I were trying to be a rock group instantly. We were never going to really stick with it, but I think we were all looking for something else to do not because we didn't like what Dave was doing but on the contrary he was doing it so well and other people were, and you know why do that? Do something else and be popular and be young —

MR: Did he ask your opinion about his compositions — because the other memory I have of the time that I spoke with him in the house was that when the interview was done he took me over to his piano to show me what he was working on that day and what did I think of it. And it was quite a moment for me. And he was writing a very sad song that apparently Iola said no one's going to want to sing this it's too sad. It was about the Afghanistan war. So I'm wondering if he sought opinions from other people, like you?

DB: Yeah. No that was like one of his characteristics, which we sometimes criticized in saying because he was so instinctive and original and intuitive as a composer. But of course it was flattering to be asked but it seemed odd in a way too.

MR: When you sit down to write if you have a goal, a specific goal in mind of — you wrote a song for his 80th birthday and you wrote something performed at Lincoln Center, do you approach this composition work differently than if you're just — you're in the mood to write, you sit and wait for something to happen. Is there a different approach depending on the goal?

DB: Oh absolutely. There's — look in terms of waiting for something to happen if I just come up with a phrase when I'm practicing — some things don't come from the brain, they come from the fingers you know. And it won't be — in my case — I'm not that brilliant that it will be complete but it will be enough to say gosh you know if I develop this, if I extend it, if I, you know, you would know all the manipulations that are possible you know I've actually got something. That's one thing. If I'm — and then you referred to Commission 2004, which was — we mentioned his name earlier with Zim Ngqawana — we co-composed it. That was for the opening of Rose Hall at Lincoln Center and it was part of a series, "Let Freedom Swing." And for your kind of footnoting you should Google that. But that had commissions for me and Zim, for Toshiko, for was it Jimmy Heath maybe. And there were a series of commissions for that week which preceded that election — it was also an election year, interestingly. And it was kind of — my commission was settings they had already selected them, of quotations from Nelson

Mandela and Archbishop Desmond Tutu. All of the other commissions were also musical settings from speeches — oh Billy Childs was another one. But anyway, get the facts because it's fascinating. I don't want to be responsible in this interview for naming everyone and getting everything exact.

MR: Right. But you have — you might have a title in mind, you're commissioned, so I'm just trying to envision that first time you sit down at the piano how does it direct the first thing you try to do. Or maybe it doesn't.

DB: Both. I guess the first thing very often will be a trick I learned from Dave which is to see if there's a verbal cue, maybe a speech rhythm. It's just like we used to learn phone numbers. Like my phone number now, I got a SIM card a few days ago so as not to forget it, it's 9534437 so I think okay well that's sort of like mid-period Stravinsky, right?

MR: Interesting.

DB: So you know I'll grab something from outside of music and try to bring it into music and then see if that does something.

MR: Are you ever away from the piano, taking a walk, and you get an idea in your head?

DB: Yeah.

MR: Like a problem solving, like you've got five minutes so far where am I going to go with this, and something speaks to you?

DB: Oh yeah, all the time. I never put — well I shouldn't say never — I very seldom, if I'm driving by myself I probably won't put the radio on in the car. On plane rides I only watch the movie if I'm very tired. I'm always processing something, and sometimes that processing is just rumination, it's just repeating and I'm still not happy with it but at least I'm getting it out of my system, and sometimes the solution will be there. But my musical brain is usually active.

MR: Can you turn it off?

DB: Yeah, yeah, just by focusing on something else. I'm not precisely turning it off but you know I'll just stop noticing it.

MR: Okay. I wanted to offer up a couple of quotes. And this one comes from Iola. Near the end of my interview with her I said, "What makes you angry?" And she paused for a moment and then she said, "Injustice — it's not a just world. I hate to see anyone treated badly, not even the right to be themselves and the stereotyping of people. That I really can't tolerate. That's where I'm intolerant." It looks to me like you inherited some of that.

DB: Yeah. Well everyone — I think everyone grows up thinking they learn the difference between right and wrong from their parents and yet we can have disagreements within our societies so we don't all learn the same things. But yeah, Iola's — the short version of what she said, what she's also said about herself is she's intolerant of intolerance. And you know I think in the family we're all like that. We've all, to one degree or another,

been involved with the Civil Rights Movement or, more overtly I've been in the political system — cultural/political struggle in South Africa. But it's not literally inherited. My wife Cathy is just the same. You know she was an activist when it was very dangerous to be one. You know once she was with me the worst thing they could do is kick us out of the country. But when she was a university student and national secretary of the Progressive Party and dealing with the, you know very heavy handed government security and intelligence organizations, or not dealing with but evading. I mean she was in a risky world for a while. And she's — all I'm saying at length is really just we're all like that. Everyone we're close to is — not just Brubecks.

MR: Here's a quote from her — it comes from the trailer of the movie "Playing the Changes." She said, "What we did here will never be as important as it was in South Africa." I hope I'm quoting that correctly but she was making the point that the work that you both did was extremely important that it happened in South Africa at the time that it did.

DB: Right. And the timing is completely central to it. If it had been too early I think it would have been smothered somehow, and if it had come too late, who cares. But it came at the right time to gather momentum, to create a cultural exch — a cultural change within the campus that was a bit ahead of the cultural change that was coming to the nation, it was successful beyond anything we could have predicted, and it planted jazz education in — every tertiary institution in South Africa that has a music department offers jazz studies. And the reason for that is simply that — well there's two reasons. One people want it, potential students want it; and two is we trained people that remained in South Africa and they looked for jobs and they found them.

MR: Well that brings me to a quote from you, which also comes from the movie trailer, in that you had a fear of being useless. And you just proved that you're way, way far away from that.

DB: Well thank you. Thank you.

MR: I admire the work that you've both done and the fact that you could take some time out because I know you're in the middle of a lot of things — a tour of the Brubeck Octet Project —

DB: Okay, I'm not touring that.

MR: Okay.

DB: But we arrived in time to see the premier of it — Jon De Lucia — at the Wilton Library. The Wilton Library in Wilton, Connecticut has become kind of a new focal point — newish because it's been going on for a few years, of Brubeck activity after the Brubeck Institute moved from the University of the Pacific to the East Coast and became directly under family control rather than, you know, kind of a coalition with the institution and so forth. So anyway that's the octet. But I am moving on to the Brubeck Jazz Summit at

Lake Tahoe where I'll be playing with Chris and Dan. And yeah, yeah, we are busy and we're setting up a book tour for next year, April of next year. You know setting up a tour means you need kind of an anchor date and then you build things around it. So right now there's too many moving parts but we know we're going to be doing something at Jazz at Lincoln Center unless they can't give us a venue, and if they can't then we'll do it at Juilliard or vice versa. But that agreement's in place. And then we're going out to Champaign-Urbana because that's the University of Illinois Press and I'm a Wesleyan alum so we'll do it at Wesleyan, Connecticut, and Emory University in Atlanta is interested. So you know who knows? But we'll have a busy itinerary. And otherwise we'll just do what old retired people do.

MR: So I want to see if — this is just an aside — if you can confirm what your brothers said about discipline in the Brubeck home. And they mentioned Grandma Myrtle?

DB: Yeah. What about her? Was it Chris?

MR: He said that she had a wapper dapper.

DB: That was a shoe tree.

MR: It was a shoe tree.

DB: Um hum. You know the old fashioned kind. Now they make them out of styrofoam or something. A shoe tree has a wedge on the end for the toe and something shaped like a heel that you put in shoes like you know if you're Cary Grant's valet you'd be doing that kind of thing and then a flexible steel band that connected the two.

MR: And what would she use it for?

DB: I remember it as a threat more than —

MR: Yes I think that's what they said. It was just something to bring up in case things were getting out of hand.

DB: Yeah.

MR: Yeah. Okay last question, and this is a bit more serious. As an American living abroad in multiple locations, and you mentioned in your conversation you've mentioned election years a couple of times and we have one now. What are your observations from abroad about the American social situation and political atmosphere?

DB: The American political atmosphere is toxic. From abroad and I mean I'm not only expressing my own opinion but the conversations I've had with South African, British, French people, is that they're shocked and I am shocked at the low quality of debate. In fact there's nothing you can call debate, it's just if you look at — and I won't even go too deeply into all of this because I don't have a lot original to say but to me it's obvious that if you look at parliamentary systems, all of which are different but they're all parliamentary systems somewhat different from ours, the leadership is accountable for what they say and they are directly challenged on the floor of — every week. Every

Thursday the British Prime Minister faces the Prime Minister's questions. It's not a press conference, they come from the opposition parties and he has to answer those questions. And the speaker of the house keeps order, and the demands can be very specific on policy matters and so like accountability isn't something that just happens in an election year, it's every week. France I'm not sure exactly what they do, they have kind of a hybrid presidential and parliamentary system but again there's a high level of accountability. And South Africa, which has not successfully become a mature democracy but at least it has this factor of debate. And politicians have to answer questions. It's not a perpetual campaign to be re-elected the way it is in the U.S. and consequently the public has a higher level of debate, even just makes meeting at the pub, on the golf course or you know whatever, there's a lot more mutual respect and civility. And there is kind of a general understanding that assertion — just shouting loudest — doesn't make you right and that lying is a bad thing. That seems to be gone in American politics. In Britain — there are things wrong with that system too but I'm just looking back at the American system. The same party has been in control for 14 years and they've gone through five prime ministers so how does that happen? That isn't to do with election cycles. In all cases they have been found out. They've had to resign or they've had to accept demotion within their party when they've been found out for telling lies or high degrees of incompetence or what the British refer to as "sleaze" (being in somebody's pocket). We don't have those mechanisms in America. You know how is it possible to elect a felon? There's no rule that says you can't. In the U.K. there may not be a rule but they have these old fashioned notions — and this will bring me to my last comment — that I suppose are the faded scrappy shreds of chivalry, an old fashioned notion of honor that if you've done wrong, okay people will say well you only regret it if you are found out. But — that may be, but you still can't, you know just become Prime Minister. It's just not the done thing old chap.

MR: Well said, thank you for sharing your opinion on that.

DB: I want — one more thing — I want —

MR: Yes, please.

DB: Okay as of this election cycle Liberals with a capital L are the new conservatives, with a small C because conservatives are radicals. Liberals believe in constitutionality, the rule of law, old fashioned values. Trump supporters — MAGA Republicans are radicals who would overthrow that order and we saw that. That's not an empty allegation, we saw that on January 6. And to kind of spy on the enemy I've kind of listened to Sean Hannity a couple of times and people like that, and read some things, and they keep shouting about the left. Looking at it from overseas I do not perceive a "Left" with a capital L. There is no Left in America. There is no consolidated Left opposition and certainly not a capital L

left. I think what they may mean, or try to make us believe applies to Democrats and green-carded people and so forth, are a kind of equally illiberal, woke group that would impose censorship on speech that they don't agree with. And again, that is not liberal, that is not left, that is just a different kind of authoritarianism. So I think you're bemused by my observation but just take it as my opinion as American has no left as such. It has opposed authoritarian groupings and that liberals, which I take you to be, are people who — of a certain age kind of took for granted the kind of life we had under Clinton and Obama and we knew there were bad guys out there but maybe not so bad. You know George Bush was just dumb but you know not evil. You could see some humanity there, but now it's polarized and toxic. On that black note I guess we're wound up.

MR: Yes, and I think we did take it for granted and I think you should be able to speak like that on CNN. So Darius, thank you for your time today. I wish you the best of luck with all the projects you have going on. I think you chose — whoever chose "Playing the Changes," the title —

DB: Yeah.

MR: It's spot on because you know playing the changes presents these issues to solve.

DB: Yeah.

MR: Like you've been solving issues for most of your life and doing it very well.

DB: Well thank you very much, Monk.

MR: All right. I'll say good-bye and best wishes to you.

DB: And to you.